

Words ending in -re or -er

Many British words that end with -re are spelled with -er in American English. This difference is commonly seen in the spelling of metric measurements, such as *metre* and *litre* in British English, compared to *meter* and *liter* in American English.

British English	American English
calibre	caliber
centre	center
fibre	fiber
lustre	luster
meagre	meager
sombre	somber
spectre	specter
theatre	theater

Words ending in -our or -or

Words that end with -our in British English often end with -or in American English. However, in British English, when one of the endings -ous, -ious, -ary, -ation, -ific, -ize, or -ise is added to a noun that ends in -our, the -our is usually changed to -or. For example, *humour* becomes *humorous*, and *glamour* becomes *glamorise*.

British English	American English
behaviour	behavior
colour	color
flavour	flavor
humour	humor
labour	labor
neighbour	neighbor
rumour	rumor
vigour	vigor

Same spelling

Many British and American words are spelled the same, regardless of the rules. In most cases, there is no reason for this and the words just have to be learned. If uncertain, check how words are spelled in a dictionary.

rebelled endurance feather
 advertise mediocre exercise
 fooling actor

REAL WORLD

Webster's Dictionary

Noah Webster (1758–1843) is frequently credited with introducing American spelling. Webster wanted to emphasize a unique American cultural identity by showing that Americans spoke a different language from the British. He also advocated spelling words phonetically. In 1828, he published *An American Dictionary of the English Language*, which forms the basis of American spelling to this day.



- American and British spellings are both **correct**, as long as one or the other is used **consistently**.
- Occasionally, American English uses the British spelling for **names**, as in the case of the space shuttle **Endeavour** or **Ford's Theatre** in Washington, D.C.